seemed to be eager to talk to me, but decided against it and exited. I heard ‘click’ noises of tape recorders. Police constable Anil remained silent. Now I was asked to get back to the room on the first floor.

As I was entering the room, an official was leaving it. He reminded me of my old classmate K Shanmugham. The officer, who appeared to be in his forties, was tall (maybe 5’11”) and of medium built. Against his wheatish complexion, a burn mark stood out below the left cheek, around the neck and shoulders. He might have had a fire accident. Later, when he interrogated me, he asked me to call him by the same name—Shanmugham—after I told him about the resemblance.

Someone brought some rice and *sambar* on a plate. I tried to eat, but could not. I left most of the food on the plate and washed my hands. And then, the first team of interrogators arrived.

The interrogators looked so different from each other that, for a moment, I thought the stark contrast was by design. One was short, small built, fair and appeared to be in his mid-30s. The other was about six foot, had a flat nose and a round face. He must have weighed 80 kg on the scale we used to measure hardware in the lab, and had the arrogance of the fiftees. During interrogation, when I asked these men their names, they said they, as a matter of the IB’s policy, never revealed their names to the accused. After a minute of what they thought was creative thinking, one said his name was *Satya* (truth); and the other *Dharma* (duty). ‘Nice names,’ I said, resisting the temptation to say that my name is ‘Neeti’ (justice).

Soon their actions made me think that they should be named after two *asuras* of the Indian *puranas*. By the way one of them spoke I inferred that he was a Keralite; he quoted from the Bible. He said he had more than twenty-five years of experience in interrogation. He continuously smoked Panama cigarettes. I learned he was a subordinate of State IB deputy director R B Sreekumar, and hence an IB man. He mockingly tried to talk very sweetly, and hence I nicknamed him Sweety.

Sweety was often accompanied by a subordinate who stopped taking notes only occasionally to abuse me. Around 5’8”, he was dark, had grey